

To launch her Secret 10 in style, declare your daughter's fifth birthday an official Family Bank Day. Let the whole gang know this is something to get excited about. This will most likely be her bank account for the rest of her life. The \$10 she deposits today will accumulate and multiply, and over the coming years, she will come to understand the value of adding to it and growing this small nest egg into one that will see her through college, marriage and building a family dynasty of her own. It's a big day, so treat it as such. Happy Bank Day!

Maybe the whole family takes a trip to the bank, or it could be something special for just you and your child. The point is to make it a rite of passage—an acknowledgement that your child has taken a big step toward adulthood. Banks can be very impressive places (make no mistake: it's your money paying for those fancy windows and vaulted ceilings). They are meant to instill equal parts fear and awe. That's good—you can work with that. Explain to your child that her money is going to be under attack from the day she's born, and the bank is leading the battle cry. It is her duty and responsibility to be aware of *every penny going in or out of that account*. Give her a ledger to help her keep track, thus getting her in the habit of diligently balancing her account. You can also point out that she will accrue a little bit of interest month by month. It won't be much, but even a few cents is exciting for a five-year-old because it's money she didn't have before.

Age 6

The Bank Machine

On your child's sixth birthday, gift her with another \$100. Reiterate the rules from the previous year—10 percent goes to the Secret 10, the rest is Meanie Money. Then offer to take the whole family out to dinner.

On the way to the restaurant, ask your child The Question: "Where does money come from?" Take the opportunity to open a family-wide dialogue, moderated by you and your partner. If you have other kids, invite them to join in. Stress the fact that money is